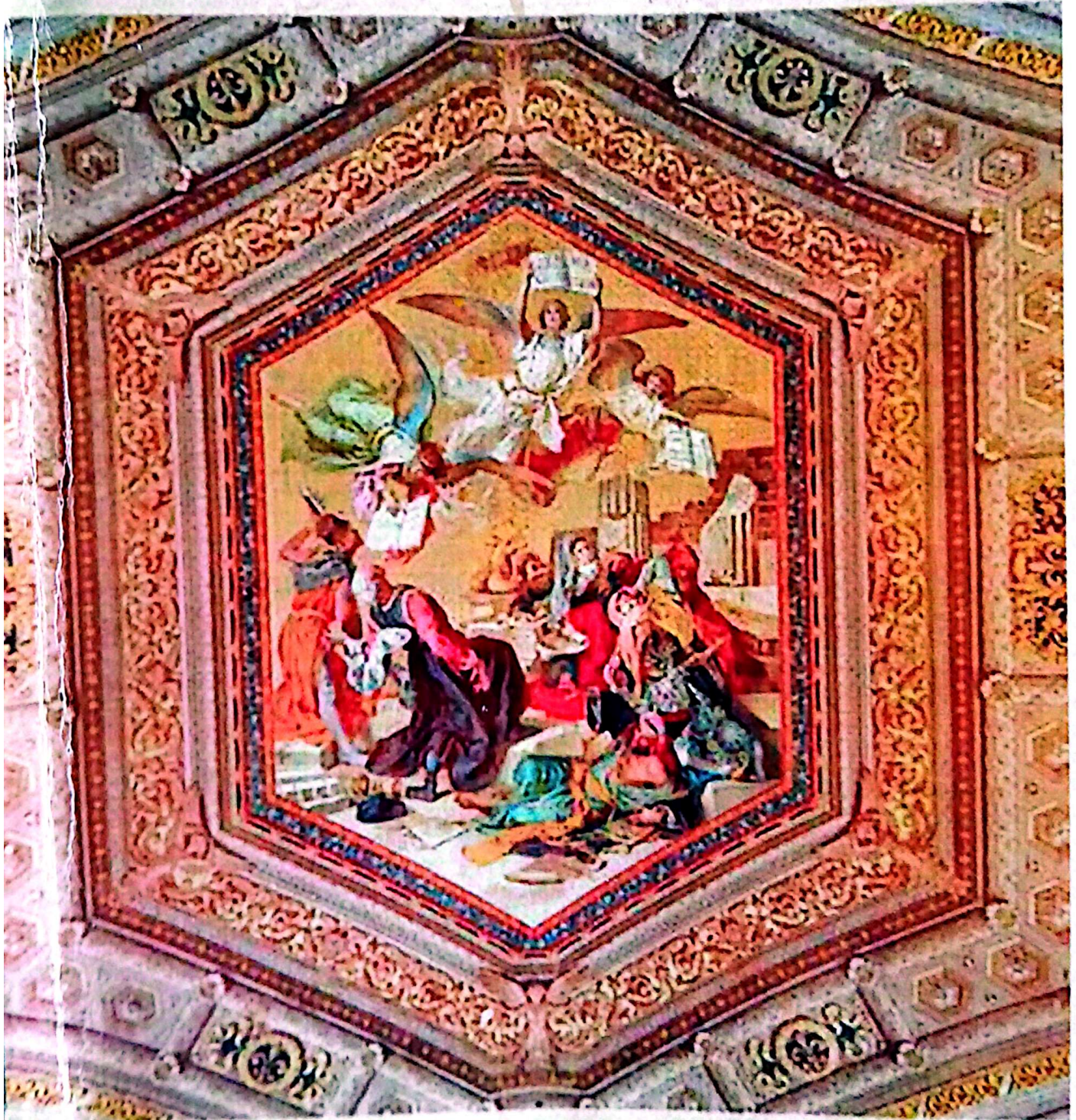


THOMAS AQUINAS'S *Summa Contra Gentiles*

A GUIDE AND COMMENTARY



BRIAN DAVIES

Necessity in Creatures, the Eternity of the World, and Distinctions among Creatures (SCG 2,30–45)

IF CREATURES DEPEND on God's will, does it follow that there can be no necessary beings other than God? Might we not say that "there are some things in the universe whose being is simply and absolutely necessary"?¹ You might suppose that we cannot say this if only God is Being Itself who exists uncaused. Yet Aquinas actually does think that some creatures are "simply and absolutely necessary," as we see from SCG 2,30.

10.1 Can There Be Created Yet Necessary Things? (SCG 2,30)

According to Aquinas something is "simply and absolutely necessary" if it is not able *to be or not to be*. One might think he regards all creatures as able to be or not to be and that he should, therefore, assume that no creature exists of absolute necessity, and Aquinas is clear that no creature has to exist by nature (since its nature and existence can be distinguished from each other, and since its existence must be caused by God). However, Aquinas does think that some things created by God have a necessity that does not conflict with the fact that what they are by nature does not entail that they exist as God does: as eternal, simple, and underived.

¹ Philosophers have often spoken about contingency and necessity by appealing to certain propositions and then applying what they have said when it comes to things that exist. Consider the proposition "No triangles are square." That seems to be logically necessary. But also consider the proposition "Australia exists." That you might think is not true of logical necessity. Indeed, if you thought that it was true of logical necessity, then you would suppose that Australia has always existed and could not possibly cease to exist. So let us say that "Australia exists" is not true of logical necessity as is "No triangles are square." In that case, Australia would seem to be something contingent, something that does not exist of logical necessity. So, it has consequently been said, there are things of two kinds: things that are logically necessary (the existence

of which it would be contradictory to deny), and things that are contingent (the existence of which it would not be contradictory to deny). Yet, though Aquinas is perfectly aware of the distinction between propositions that are logically necessary and propositions that are not, he thinks that there are creatures of God that are necessary while other ones are contingent.

That is because Aquinas takes necessary creatures to be ones that (1) do not arise by a process of generation, and (2) cannot be annihilated by what exists in the material world. He says:

Some things are so created by God that there is in their nature a potentiality to non-being; and this results from the fact that the matter present in them is in potentiality with respect to another form. On the other hand, neither immaterial things, nor things whose matter is not receptive of another form, have potentiality to non-being, so that their being is absolutely and simply necessary.²

Aquinas's distinction between creatures that are necessary and creatures that are contingent is not the distinction between what is logically necessary and logically contingent. It flags a difference between actually existing things created by God, and Aquinas, therefore, does not think that there being necessary created things conflicts with the view that all creatures depend for their existence on God's will.

You might think that if creatures come to be from nothing, then none of them can be necessary. However, though Aquinas accepts that all creatures derive from God, and though he is certain that God might never have created since (1) God does not need creatures and since (2) no agent can compel God to do anything, he does not think it therefore follows that there can be no created necessary things. Such things, Aquinas holds, are just beings of a certain kind, beings that could be and that, therefore, can be created by God. "To be simply necessary," says Aquinas, "is not incompatible with the notion of created being; for nothing prevents a thing being necessary whose necessity nevertheless has a cause, as in the case of the conclusions of demonstrations. Hence, nothing prevents certain things being produced by God in such fashion that they exist in a simply necessary way; indeed, this is a proof of God's perfection."³

10.2 Must Creatures Always Have Existed? (SCG 2,31-38)

If there are necessary creatures caused to be by God, however, should we not suppose that at least some creatures have always existed? Aristotle held that

the world had no beginning, and other philosophers, especially ancient ones, have argued to the same effect.⁴ So might we not indeed suppose that creatures have always existed, or that the physical universe, at any rate, never began to be?

Aquinas turns to these questions in SCG 2,31. To start with, he argues that it is not necessary for creatures always to have existed (SCG 2,31). In subsequent chapters he notes and comments on arguments for and against the conclusion that the universe has always existed (SCG 2,32–38). His overall view is: (1) it cannot be proved that the universe has always existed; (2) it cannot be proved that the universe began to exist; (3) God must account for the existence of the universe whether or not it had a beginning. As I noted in chapter 3, Aquinas did believe that the universe had a beginning since he took this to be taught by the Old Testament book of Genesis. However, in several of his writings, including the SCG, he views the teaching that the world began to be as a truth of faith, not something demonstrable as some of his contemporaries took it to be.⁵

When it comes to the thesis that it is necessary for creatures always to have existed, Aquinas's position is that creatures only exist because God wills them to exist, implying that there might not have been any creatures at all, let alone ones always existing. This is the argument of SCG 2,31. Here Aquinas says:

Nothing proceeding from a will is absolutely necessary, except when it chances to be necessary for the will to will it. But, as we have shown [see SCG 2,23], God brings creatures into being not through a necessity of his nature, but voluntarily. Nor, as proved in Book 1, does he necessarily will the existence of creatures [see SCG 1,81]. Hence, it is not absolutely necessary for the creature to be, and therefore neither is it necessary for creatures to have existed always.⁶

Why might one think that the world has existed always and of necessity? Or why might one think that it cannot always have existed? With respect to the first question, Aquinas notes arguments of three kinds: (1) those taking their stand on what God is, (2) those taking their stand on what creatures are, and (3) those taking their stand on what is involved in making. Aquinas spells out these arguments in SCG 2,32–34, while replying to them in SCG 2,35–37. With respect to the question “Why suppose that the world cannot always have existed?” in SCG 2,38 Aquinas lists arguments in favor of the claim “The world is not eternal” while also maintaining that, though they are “not devoid of probability,” they “lack absolute and necessary conclusiveness.” In this chapter of the SCG, Aquinas insists on the fact that belief that the world began to be is to be held by faith alone.

So what are the arguments that Aquinas notes in favor of the claim that the world must always have existed? They run as follows. (And when reading the summaries of them, remember that they are arguments that Aquinas goes on to reject.)

10.2.1 Arguments Based on What God Is (SCG 2,32)

1. God is not moved at all. So he always acts in the same way. Since God and his will are eternal, God must therefore make creatures that always exist since God is eternal, as is his will.
2. God's action is eternal, so things created by God must always have existed.
3. God is a cause that has it in him to produce creatures and cannot be thwarted from doing so should he do so willingly. So, given that God causes creatures, and given that God is eternal, creatures will always exist.
4. Voluntary agents do not delay in carrying out their purposes unless they are prevented from doing so. But God is eternal, and nothing within himself or outside himself can impede his action. So if the eternal God wills creatures to exist, they will always exist.
5. Agents with intellect do not choose one thing over another unless motivated by preferable differences of some kind in what they might choose. But there is no difference between two things neither of which exist. So God cannot be motivated to produce creatures that begin to exist as opposed to creatures that do not begin to exist. Indeed, if God eternally wills that creatures exist, creatures always exist.
6. Creatures willed by God are directed to God as an end. They are directed to goodness that exists in God before it exists in them. But God's goodness is unchangeable, so creatures are willed by God from eternity and must, therefore, always exist.
7. God's goodness is infinite, so God must will some creatures always to have existed in order to share always in God's goodness.

10.2.2 Arguments Based on What Creatures Are (SCG 2,33)

1. Some creatures are necessary beings (see SCG 2,30). So some creatures have always existed.
2. Some creatures have a power to exist forever, so they exist always, which means that they never began to exist.
3. When something begins to be changed there has to occur change of some kind either in what changes or in what is changed. So every change is

- either eternal or is preceded by some change, which means that change and things changed have always existed given that God is immutable.
4. Things that generate other things aim to keep their species in being. "Now, it is impossible that natural desire should be futile. The species of generable things, therefore, must be perpetual."⁷
 5. If time is everlasting, then so is change, and so are created substances. Yet time is everlasting since what is "now" is always preceded by a previous time, and since to deny that time always exists involves supposing a time before it existed and a time after it ceases to exist.
 6. Some propositions are such that to deny them is to assert them. For example, to deny that truth exists is to assert that something is true. Yet such propositions and what follows from them are everlasting, which means that there is something other than God that is eternal.

10.2.3 Arguments Based on What Is Involved in Making (SCG 2,34)

1. If something is made, it has to be made from something. Now, God is not made. But everything that is made must be made from something, which means that something other than God is eternal.
2. "A movable subject must exist prior to anything made" and "since to proceed to infinity in this matter is impossible, we must come to a first subject not newly originated but always existent."⁸
3. If something begins to exist, then before it existed it was possible for it to exist. So, before anything begins to exist, there must be something that is "potentially a being," and since an infinite regress is impossible in this connection, there is some primary subject that did not begin to exist.
4. Nothing permanent exists while it is being made. Yet while something is being made, there must be something that is in process of being made. So "whatever is made has some pre-existing subject."⁹ Since this cannot go on to infinity, there must be a first and everlasting unmade subject, and there must, in that case, be something other than God that is eternal, since God is not something being made and since God is not changed by anything.

10.2.4 Aquinas's Responses to the Arguments Based on What God Is (SCG 2,35)

As I have said, Aquinas rejects all the above arguments, and in response to those found in SCG 2,32, he replies as follows (the numeration below corresponds to that in section 10.2.1).

1. God need not be changed in any way as his effects begin to exist; and something coming to be does not entail that there is any coming to be in God.
2. The fact that God is eternal does not mean that his effects are eternal. That is because God makes creatures voluntarily and can decide when something begins to exist. "Nothing, therefore, prevents our saying that God's action existed from all eternity, whereas its effect was not present from eternity, but existed, at that time when, from all eternity, he ordained it."¹⁰
3. God may suffice to bring things into being, but the fact that God is eternal does not imply that his effects are eternal. God's willing that something should exist does not mean that the thing has to exist eternally, as does God's will.
4. "Within the scope of God's will fall not only the existence of his effect but also the time of its existence."¹¹ The effects of God's will are not delayed even though they do not always exist, and that a creature should exist at a certain time is not delayed even though God wills it to be from eternity.
5. "Nothingness has neither measure nor duration."¹² And there are no parts in God, who is immutable. So we should not think of the beginning of creatures as something God produced because he acts with an eye on what it would be good for him to produce in some context in which he finds himself. Nor should we think that the coming to be of creatures has to be related to time or place, as a thing coming to be in the world has to be related to a particular time and place since there has to be a reason why it comes to be at some particular time and in some particular place. So we do not need to seek a reason explaining why and when a creature came to exist. "We have only to ask why it was not always produced, or why it was produced after not being or with some beginning."¹³
6. God eternally wills his own goodness, and he does not act so as to bring this about as we might act so as to bring about ends that we desire. God is eternal and immutable, so he gains nothing by his willing of creatures. Therefore, if God wills creatures to exist, he does so in order that they might somehow share in his goodness, and in doing this God does not have to create what has always existed.
7. In order to share his goodness with creatures, God does not have to create things that are eternal as he is. Indeed, God creating a world which has a beginning "makes it perfectly clear that all things other than God have God as the author of their being."¹⁴

10.2.5 Aquinas's Responses to the Arguments Based on What Creatures Are (SCG 2,36)

In response to the arguments summarized by Aquinas in SCG 2,33, Aquinas replies as follows (the numeration below corresponds to that in section 10.2.1)

1. Created necessary beings are created by God willingly, so they might never have existed.
2. Even if a creature has a power to exist always, it is still a creature that exists only by God's will. Even a creature with a power to exist always might not be eternal.
3. Creatures do not exist because of a change in God, who can will something to begin to exist and can will that the thing in question is not eternal. Creatures exist by God's simple will, which can extend to the bringing about of change having a beginning.
4. Natural agents may aim to perpetuate their species, but they have to exist in order to do that. So the argument from perpetuation of species does not settle whether or not there are creatures that have existed from eternity.
5. The fifth argument *presupposes* that change is eternal; it does not prove that change is eternal.
6. If time had a beginning, it would exist having previously not existed. Yet time might never have existed in the sense that there might never have been any change. So the fact that time might never have been does not entail that there have to be eternal creatures.
7. "The truth of propositions whose denial entails their affirmation... possesses the necessity of that order which obtains between predicate and subject. By such necessity, therefore, a thing is not compelled to exist everlastingly, except perhaps the divine intellect, in which all truth is rooted" (see SCG 1,62).

10.2.6 Aquinas's Responses to the Arguments Based on What Is Involved in Making (SCG 2,37)

In response to the arguments summarized by Aquinas in SCG 2,34, Aquinas replies as follows (the numeration below corresponds to that in section 10.2.3).

1. "Nothing comes from nothing" is true in the sense that things in the world that arise over time depend on there being something that precedes them. Yet the existence of any creature at all derives from God considered not as a being in the world acting so as to modify things somehow but as the source of there being any creatures at all rather than nothing. "Now, in this production of all being from God it is impossible for anything to be made from some other pre-existing thing; otherwise, this procession would not consist in the making of all created being."¹⁵ In general, making involves change; but we can extend the meaning of the word "make" so as to recognize that "anything at all whose essence or nature originates from something else is made."¹⁶

2. "Since that which in no way exists is not in any particular state, the idea of motion used in the argument does not warrant the conclusion that, when a thing begins to be, it is *in another state now than it was before*."¹⁷
3. There need be no passive potentiality preceding the existence of all created being. When things come about because of a process of change, there is something potentially able to be changed prior to the change in question. Yet creation is not a matter of a change occurring. Creatures, which might never have existed, were always able to be since God, from eternity, is able to make creatures. This, however, does not mean that creatures have always existed with a passive potentiality.
4. "In things made by way of motion, *to be made* and *to be* are not simultaneous, because the production of such things involves succession. But in things that are not made by way of motion, the making does not precede the being."¹⁸

10.3 Proving That the World Is Not Eternal (SCG 2,38)

Aquinas concludes SCG 2,37 by summarizing his findings concerning the thesis that the world has always existed. He writes: "In the light of all this, then, it is clear that nothing stands in the way of one's holding that the world has not always existed—a truth which the Catholic faith affirms."¹⁹ Yet how should we respond to the claim that it can be proved that the world is not eternal? In SCG 2,38 Aquinas notes six arguments in defense of this claim, though he finds none of them persuasive.²⁰

The arguments noted by Aquinas run thus.

1. If God causes all things, he must precede in duration the things that he produces.
2. If all being is created by God, it cannot be made from something and must be made from nothing. So it must have being after not being.
3. "An infinite number of things cannot be traversed."²¹ But if the world has always existed, an infinite number of things would have been traversed by now.
4. One cannot add to the infinite. However, on the supposition that the world has always existed, infinity would seem to be added to daily as one event or process follows another.
5. If the world has always existed, there can be an infinite series of efficient causes. But there cannot be such a series.

6. If the world has always existed, there would exist an infinite number of immortal souls of people who died in the past. But there cannot be such a number of souls.

Aquinas rejects argument 1 here by saying that an agent need not necessarily precede the effect that results from its operation. He agrees that there is such preceding when it comes to agents that bring things about by a process of change having a beginning and end initiated by an agent that exists as the process of change starts. But, he adds, things can also act instantly so as to bring about an effect that does not follow from a process of change in that on which they are acting.

In response to the second argument, Aquinas has this to say:

If the proposition (a) *something is made from something* is not admitted, then the contradictory of it which must be given is: (b) *something is not made from something*, and not (c) *something is made from nothing*, except in the sense of proposition (b). And from this it cannot be concluded that something is made after not-being.²²

In other words, so Aquinas is arguing, while God may creatively make all beings from nothing, all that this means is that God makes creatures, but not out of anything.

Aquinas deals with argument 3 by saying that, although the infinite does not exist all at once, it can exist successively, meaning that, in a certain sense, any infinite is finite. For example, any given revolution of the earth around the sun is finite, even if there are or have been an infinite number of such revolutions.²³ And such finite revolutions can be over and done with regardless of how many of them have occurred. Here Aquinas seems to be saying that an infinite number of past and distinct processes can, taken individually, each be completed, even if the world never had a beginning, and even if one cannot, accordingly, speak of a *first* process resulting in a *final* one.

Concerning argument 4, Aquinas's line is that "there is no reason why an addition should not be made to the infinite on that side of it which is finite."²⁴ Here Aquinas seems to mean that, even if the world never began to exist (if nothing in it was ever first), it does not follow that there cannot have occurred successive comings-to-be in the world of finite things. He writes: "From the supposition of the eternity of time it follows that time is infinite in relation to the prior but finite in relation to the posterior; for the present is the terminal point of the past."²⁵

With respect to the fifth argument, based on the idea that there cannot be an endless series of efficient causes, Aquinas draws on the distinction I noted

in chapter 3 between a causal series *per accidens* (in which things act in succession as merely preceding each other in time), and one *per se* (in which there is a single cause running through the whole series). He agrees that there cannot be an infinite series of efficient causes insofar as the causes in the series act as instruments of a single cause. But he sees no reason why there cannot be an endless series of causes each of which depends only on the action of something prior to it in time, as, say, people who are born depend on their parents having copulated. Or, as Aquinas writes: "It is accidental to Socrates' father whether he is another man's son or not. But it is not accidental to the stick, in moving the stone, that it be moved by the hand; for the stick moves just so far as it is moved."²⁶ According to Aquinas, there cannot be an infinite regression when it comes to causes that are all instruments of some primary cause and whose causing depends on the activity of something other than them. Yet there can be an infinite regression when it comes to causes that are not, in this sense, instruments through which something is working that enables or empowers them to cause as they do.

When it comes to argument 6, Aquinas admits that it is not easy to refute. However, he goes on to say, that is because it depends on how we think of human souls and their survival after death. After all, Aquinas reasons, the argument is not going to work if we suppose that human souls do not survive at all, or do not survive intact, when people perish. Nor is it going to work if we suppose that human souls return to inhabit bodies. In short, thinks Aquinas, argument 6 is hardly a knockdown one since it takes many things for granted. Here, I take him to be saying that the argument is too vague to be considered as a demonstration.

10.4 *Distinction among Creatures (SCG 2,39–45)*

I have now shown Aquinas arguing at length that God exists and that God wills all creatures into being. For Aquinas, God is the answer to the question "How come something rather than nothing?" Yet Aquinas obviously recognizes that God has not just created one thing. The universe is full of different things—not only things that are different numerically within a kind (there are, for example, many different cats) but things that are different with respect to kinds (there are, for example, dogs as well as cats). In short, the created order contains many different things of many different kinds. It contains numerous individuals and numerous kinds of individuals. In that case, however, one might reasonably ask not just "How come something rather than nothing?" but "How come numerical differences and differences in the kinds of things that there are?" After all, if, as Aquinas thinks, God is free to will

whatever can be, why is there a world with diversity and difference rather than a world containing no diversity and difference?

This question is partly what Aquinas is concerned with in SCG 2,39–45. In these chapters he honors his promise in SCG 2,5 to consider distinction among creatures once he has spoken about the bringing of creatures into being. Yet in SCG 2,39–45 Aquinas is also concerned to work to the conclusion that it is God alone who is the true first cause of differences between creatures. Aquinas defends this conclusion in SCG 2,45, which I take to be the most important chapter in the section of the SCG I am now discussing.

Before he gets to that chapter, however, Aquinas spends time denying that distinctions between things can be properly accounted for in terms of theories that do not invoke God. So let us see what he has to say on this front.

10.4.1 Distinction Is Not the Result of Chance (SCG 2,39)

You might think that chance or randomness accounts for all variety in the world, and evolutionary biologists certainly invoke the notion of chance or randomness when talking about the evolution of species. That chance accounts for *all* variety seems hardly plausible since some things come about in predictable ways. It is not, for example, an accident that baby tigers spring from adult ones.²⁷ So it is not a matter of chance that there are more than two tigers. As I say, though, evolutionary theories, which do not claim that all variety arises from chance, do assign a serious role to chance.

That said, however, you will look in vain for any discussion of evolution in SCG 2,39. Aquinas has no notion of evolution in the senses that people have construed it since the time of Charles Darwin (1809–1882). On the other hand one might wonder whether he would be an antievolutionist were he writing today, if only because his philosophical view of God as the creator of everything is neutral when it comes to the value of particular scientific theories. For Aquinas, God makes everything to exist as what it is. How things in the world derive from other things in the world, or how events in the world connect with other events, is not the subject matter of his natural theology. This fundamentally maintains that God operates in every operation and is not one more thing for scientists to get their hands on. More important, though, Aquinas's discussion of chance in SCG 2,39 is not intended as a prescient refutation of theories of evolution by natural selection. Its aim is to deny that diversity is derived from chance. And one reason Aquinas thinks that it does not so derive is that he takes all creatures to spring from God's eternal will, which he certainly does not believe to be a random process or something coming about by chance. As he writes in SCG 2,39:

The form of any thing proceeding from an intellectual and voluntary agent is intended by that agent. But, as we have seen [see SCG 2,23 and 24], the universe of creatures has as its author God, who is a voluntary and intellectual agent. Nor can there be any defect in his power so that he might fail in accomplishing his intention; for, as we proved in Book 1 of this work, his power is infinite [see SCG 1,43]. It therefore follows of necessity that the form of the universe is intended and willed by God, and, for that reason it is not the result of chance. For it is things outside the scope of the agent's intention that we say are fortuitous. Now the form of the universe consists in the distinction and order of its parts. The distinction of things, therefore, is not the result of chance.²⁸

10.4.2 Is Matter the First Cause of the Distinction of Things? (SCG 2,40)

As I have said, Aquinas has a notion of matter that takes it to be the potentiality for change that things in the world have. Matter, for Aquinas, is what things that can change must have, though it is not a substance and lacks form (since it is open to receiving different forms). But could matter, in this sense, be the first cause of distinction between things? Aquinas thinks that it cannot since it is form, not matter, that accounts for distinction. Diverse things in the world have matter, he agrees. But, he says, what they are, as the different kinds of things that they are, is not what they are because they have matter. Their "whatness" is due to their form or forms, and it is also, in some cases, due to the forms of agents who act on things. Or, as Aquinas says, "It is by their forms that things are distinguished into species. Therefore, it is not in the diversity of matter that the first cause of the distinction of things is to be found."²⁹

10.4.3 Does Diversity Derive from Different Agents? (SCG 2,41)

Could it be that diversity in the world is primarily caused by a diversity of things? In SCG 2,41 Aquinas argues that it cannot. Among other things, he makes the obvious point that we cannot account for diversity in things by noting that there are things that are themselves diverse. He writes:

The first cause of the distinction of things cannot be things whose distinction from one another itself is caused. Yet, if we consider several agents of the same order, their distinction from one another must necessarily have a cause; for their being itself is caused, since, as we have

shown [see SCG 2,15], all beings are from one first being. But we have just proved that the cause of a thing's being, and of its distinction from other things, is the same [see SCG 2,24]. Diversity of agents, therefore, cannot possibly be the first cause of the distinction among things.³⁰

In SCG 2,41, however, Aquinas has some fairly precise targets at which he aims when denying that differences in the created order derive from different things. For he knows that some have claimed that there is a good cause for good things and a bad cause for bad things. He is aware that it has been said that "all good things proceed from a good principle and evils from an evil principle."³¹ Aquinas takes this line of thinking to have been defended by certain ancient philosophers. He alludes, for example, to Empedocles (c. 495–430 B.C.), who taught that all things in nature are moved by two opposing causes: Love and Strife. Aquinas also thinks that, since the rise of Christianity, the notion of there being two opposing principles behind things in the world was especially championed by the Manicheans.³² So in SCG 2,41 Aquinas comments critically on there being a good principle (first cause) of what is good and a bad principle of what is bad.

He argues that there cannot be one first principle of all evils since such a thing would be evil by essence and since nothing can be evil by essence because evil amounts to privation of some kind in what is good to start with (see SCG 1,39). He writes: "Everything that is must necessarily be good in so far as it is a being.... It is, therefore, impossible for the distinction among things to proceed from two contrary principles, the one good, the other evil."³³ Aquinas does not mean that everything that exists is *entirely* good. Indeed, he thinks that many things are bad or defective in various ways. Yet he also thinks that, in order to be a bad such and such or a defective such and such, something has to succeed in being what it takes to exist as the kind of thing that it is. It is in this sense that he holds that everything is good insofar as it has being. So he maintains that the very being of something (what it is essentially) cannot consist only of badness.

In SCG 2,41 Aquinas goes on to make these points:

1. If agents act insofar as they have goodness to some extent, something evil of itself could never be an agent. So, "every agent, as such, is good," and nothing can be the first principle of evils if it is evil of itself or by nature.³⁴
2. Since evil amounts to nonbeing, and since efficient causes produce what reflects them, there cannot be an efficient cause of nonbeing. "No cause that is of itself active in character can be assigned to evil as such. Evils cannot, then, be referred to one first cause that is of itself the cause of all evils."³⁵

Something that comes about without being aimed at by anyone or anything comes about accidentally. Since all agents aim at what is good, therefore, evil can only arise in their effects without being aimed at. "Evil, therefore, has no essential cause, but occurs accidentally in the effects of causes. Hence, there is no question of maintaining the existence of one first principle of all evils."³⁶

We have no reason to explain the difference between good and evil in things with reference to contrary agents (agents that, though different, might both exist) since contrary agents have contrary actions and since "contrary principles are not to be attributed to things produced by one action."³⁷ Yet good and evil are produced by the same action.³⁸

Something lacking being entirely is neither good nor evil, while whatever has being is somehow good. So "a thing must be evil so far as it is a non-being."³⁹ Therefore, what is evil as such is deprived of being and cannot be an active agent cause in the coming about of what is evil or bad.

10.4.4 The First Cause of the Distinction in Things Is Not the World of Secondary Agents (SCG 2,42)

In SCG 2,42 Aquinas rejects a line of thinking that can be represented as follows.

- Since God is one and simple, he produces just one effect.
- This effect is not equal to God when it comes to simplicity, but it can produce differences of some kind.
- From this scenario a series of causes results that represents degrees of falling away from divine simplicity, and diversity in things derives from the activity of causes other than God.

Aquinas seems to think that something like this was the view of Avicenna.⁴⁰ Whether it was or was not, however, Aquinas rejects it for several reasons.

For example, he says, God's power is not limited to producing only one effect (see SCG 2,22), and this conclusion does not contradict the teaching that God is entirely simple. So "it is not necessary to say that because God is one and absolutely simple, no multiplicity can proceed from him unless it be through the mediation of certain things lacking in the simplicity proper to himself."⁴¹ Again, says Aquinas: "It was shown above [see SCG 2,21] that God alone can create" and that all that is not God has to derive from God and not anything else.⁴²

10.4.5 Distinction Does Not Result from a Secondary Cause Introducing Forms into Matter; Nor Does It Result from Differences in Merit or Demerit (SCG 2,43 and 44)

With SCG 2,43 and 44 we find Aquinas rejecting some rather arcane and implausible views over which I do not intend to linger. Just for the record, though, these views are (1) that God created matter, but an angel gave it different forms, and (2) that God made all spiritual and rational creatures equal; some of these fell away from God; this led God, out of justice, to establish divergent grades of spiritual substances and different grades among corporeal substances.⁴³ With respect to the first view, Aquinas, among other things, argues (1) that there are beings that cannot have been formed out of matter (here he is thinking of heavenly bodies), and (2) that to be is to have form, implying that, as cause of all that has being, God is the first cause of all forms. With respect to the second view, Aquinas maintains that diversity among creatures has to derive not from choices made by creatures but from the intention of the first cause willing the great good of a universe consisting of different things. Aquinas recognizes that Origen's theory, as reported in SCG 2,44, was offered by him since he thought that diversity in things must, if justice is to be preserved, be connected, somehow, to diversity of merit. But he goes on to say:

Origen seems not to have taken into consideration the fact that when we give something, not in payment of a debt, but as a free gift, it is not contrary to justice if we give unequal things, without having weighed the difference of merits; although payment is due to those who merit. But, as we have shown above [see SCG 2,28], God brought things into being, not because He was in any way obliged to do so, but out of pure generosity. Therefore, the diversity of creatures does not presuppose diversity of merit.⁴⁴

10.4.6 The True First Cause of the Distinction of Things (SCG 2,45)

So what is the true first cause of the distinction among things? Obviously, Aquinas thinks that this is God, and he argues to this effect in SCG 2,45, to which I referred above. He concludes the chapter by saying: "The diversity and inequality in created things are not the result of chance, nor of a diversity of matter, nor of the intervention of certain causes or merits, but of the intention of God himself, who wills to give the creature such perfection as it is possible

to have."⁴⁵ Given his view of God as developed previously in SCG 1 and 2, Aquinas surely has to reach such a conclusion.

10.5 *Some Comments on SCG 2,30-45*

Ancient and medieval thinkers devoted a lot of time to discussing the question "Has the world existed for ever?"⁴⁶ Aquinas was among their number, and what he says in SCG 2,31-38 is one of his more detailed discussions of the question. But is Aquinas right in what he argues here?

Like all of his Christian contemporaries, Aquinas believed that the universe began to exist. He did so on the basis of Genesis 1 and because of what the Catholic Church officially taught from the time of the Fourth Lateran Council.⁴⁷ Yet Aquinas did not think it inconceivable that the universe might never have had a beginning, while some of his contemporaries thought it possible to prove that it had to have had a beginning. So do we have reason to think that the universe must have had a beginning? And does Aquinas say enough to show that the universe might not have had a beginning?

You may think that nothing Aquinas argues serves to show that the universe might never have had a beginning since it now seems to be scientifically established that it did. Here, of course, I am referring to the big bang theory, which is currently accepted by many scientific cosmologists.

Hence, for example, Richard Swinburne can say: "There is no doubt that the models best substantiated today are ones which show the Universe expanding from a 'big bang' some 14,000 million years ago. These models successfully predict not merely the density and rate of recession of the galaxies, but the ratio of the various chemical elements to each other and to radiation in the universe, and above all the background radiation."⁴⁸

Of course, even if we accept the big bang theory in some form, there presumably remains the possibility that the big bang did not amount to an absolute beginning of things and might in some way have followed what preexisted it materially. Defenders of the big bang theory would typically say that they have given us reason to suppose that we can trace the history of the universe to a certain point. Yet is that enough to warrant us supposing that there was, in no sense, a material "before" prior to that point with respect to which the big bang might be an effect or result? As far as I can gather, it is not at all uncommon for contemporary cosmologists to admit that they are ignorant concerning whether the beginning of the universe as we know it, considered as expanding and filled with matter that has cooled, marks an absolute physical beginning.⁴⁹

On the other hand, though, the universe, as Aquinas conceived of it, does seem to have had a dateable beginning. Aquinas's cosmology takes the earth

always to have been at the center of a stable arrangement of things in which stars form a perimeter. So you may think that his claim that the universe cannot be shown to have had a beginning has been falsified by science since his day since it rests on a view of the universe that is now antiquated. Suppose, however, that we forget about scientific arguments concerning the start of the universe and focus on philosophical ones of the kind in which Aquinas engages in his discussion of the eternity of the world in SCG 2. Who wins when it comes to the question "Can it be proved that the universe had a beginning"?

As Aquinas notes, it has been argued that the universe must have had a beginning since if past time is infinite, an infinity of events would (impossibly) have to have elapsed or been traversed before today. Yet this argument, as J. L. Mackie observes, "just expresses a prejudice against an actual infinite."⁵⁰ As Mackie goes on to say: "It assumes that, even if past time were infinite, there would still have to have been a starting-point of time, but one infinitely remote, so that an actual infinity would have had to be traversed to reach the present from there. But to take the hypothesis of infinity seriously would be to suppose that there was no starting-point, not even an infinitely remote one, and that from any specific point in past time there is only a finite stretch that needs to be traversed to reach the present."⁵¹

As you will realize, this is what Aquinas argues in response to the third argument he discusses in SCG 2,38. You might reject it by saying that there is something problematic with the claim that the universe never had a beginning since, if that were correct, then it would, in principle, be possible for someone truly to say "I have just finished counting backward from infinity." Yet counting involves taking a starting number, while if the universe never began to exist there is no starting number from which to start counting backward.

You might say that an infinite number of past years cannot have occurred before the present since that would mean that infinity has an end. Yet an infinite number of past years might have elapsed if, in an infinite number of past years, there is no beginning or starting year. And if there is no beginning or starting year, then "we cannot imagine that the beginningless series of past years has been subjected to counting in any straightforward way, for it has no first member to match the first number used in counting."⁵²

You might say that what is infinite cannot have an end and that the past ended just now. But there is no reason to suppose that an infinite series cannot have one end. After all, the series of positive whole numbers has an end at zero.

You might say that, while there might be an infinity of future events with no end to them, there cannot have been an infinity of past events since an infinite future is potential while an infinite past must be completed by now. Yet to suppose an infinite number of past years is not to suppose that they have

two termini, one of which is the present moment and one of which is way back in time. Past years do not start from now, even if our thoughts about past years do so; and if the universe had no beginning, then past years did not have a starting point and do not have a finishing point, meaning that today could have arrived after infinite past time and that there can be days or moments after today. If past time had a starting point, then it would be impossible for an infinite number of days to have been fitted in between then and now. But if there is no starting point to the history of the universe, there is nothing to be fitted in between a first point and today.

This is not a book on cosmology and infinity, but I would like to conclude this chapter by suggesting that it is not obvious that to suppose that the world never had a beginning leads to manifest absurdities and that a case can be made in defense of Aquinas's SCG claim that it has not been proved that the world had a beginning.

As I have noted, however, Aquinas, unlike Aristotle and many ancient Greek philosophers, did think that the universe began to be.⁵³ Contrary to people who assume that "Does God exist?" means "Was there a God who got the universe going some time in the past?" Aquinas thinks that God exists as making things to exist at any time, and whether or not the world began to be. So Aquinas's natural theology in the SCG is not committed to theological claims to the effect that the universe had a beginning. In Aquinas we have a theologian who is taken by many Christians to be a highly orthodox thinker. It is not for nothing that he has been proclaimed by the Catholic Church to be a doctor of the faith. We might, therefore, wonder whether it is true, as some have said, that one cannot be a Christian if one thinks that the universe never had a beginning.

Once again, though, Aquinas *did* think that the universe began to exist. And he takes it to contain creatures of different kinds. Also, as I have shown, in SCG 2,5 Aquinas says that he intends in what follows to write (1) about the bringing forth of things into being, (2) about distinctions among things, and (3) about "the nature of these same things, brought forth and distinct from one another, so far as it is relevant to the truth of the faith."⁵⁴ In SCG 2 Aquinas deals with (1) and (2) in chapters 6–45. In SCG 2,46 Aquinas begins to follow up on his promise concerning (3). So let us now follow him as he does so.